

Security watch

Government requests for user data has been on the rise and a study details how many victims lose data to phishing

Mobile watch

Say good-bye to cracked screens because Gorilla Glass 4 is here and get ready as Oneplus One ties up with Amazon India

Office for iOS and Android is now free and Google launches Messenger

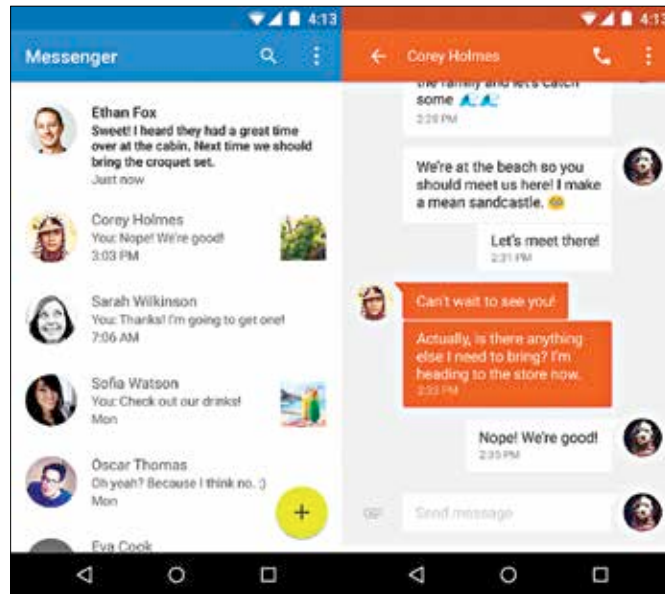
WhatsApp's new blue-ticks feature made optional post massive negative user feedback

Messenger: Google's new standalone messaging app for Android

Google has released a standalone messaging app for Android on Google Play store. Called Messenger, the application features Google's new Material Design, though supports devices running Android 4.1, Jelly Bean, and above.

Google Messenger, like the traditional SMS app, lets you send and receive SMS and MMS messages to any phone. You can also send group texts and images, videos and audio messages to texts. The Messenger app lets you search through contacts and conversation threads. It also gives you the option to block SMS senders. Other features include coloured text threads, message archiving and emoji support.

With the new Messenger, Google aims to reach out to users who haven't been using Hangouts for SMS. Contrary to rumours, Google's new Messenger doesn't seem to be a



Messenger for Android, yet another messaging app

threat to the likes of WhatsApp, Facebook Messenger, Viber and other popular messaging apps.

Google is often criticised for forcing users to use its applications. Its Hangouts application was criticized for having a tight integration with Google+, which many believe could lead unwilling users to share personal information to others.

It will be really interesting to see how Google manages its Hangouts and Messenger applications. Will these two apps be interlinked?

You can download Messenger for Android here:

<http://dgit.in/1vkFWec>

Microsoft Office suite is now free for iPhone, iPad and Android

Microsoft has announced that it's making Office apps free for iPad, iPhone and Android – a move considered to be a major shift in strategy for the company. This allows users, even those who haven't subscribed to Office 365 to create and edit documents in Word, Excel and Powerpoint for free.

Microsoft has rolled out the free version of Office for iPhone and iPad, while a preview version has been launched for Android. Full release of the

Android version is expected in 2015. Microsoft, however, is keeping some premium features for Office 365 subscribers such as unlimited OneDrive storage and Dropbox integration.

"Anytime someone has an idea or an inspiration, we want to empower them to take action," says John Case, Corporate Vice President, Office, Microsoft. "With over a billion Office customers worldwide, and over 40 million downloads on the iPad, it's clear that Office applications are what people want to use to get things done."

As said above, Microsoft's latest move is a major shift in strategy, though not a very surprising one. The company had already hinted at extending its services on other platforms after launching Office for iPad. It had also allowed users with Office 365 subscription to edit and create new documents.

Microsoft is already bearing the brunt of depleting laptops and desktop computers across the world. Meanwhile, rival Google has been working consistently to improve its productivity suite for mobile phones.

That said, Microsoft is taking a huge risk by making Office free for use. A New York Times report says Office has contributed nearly a third of Microsoft's revenue during its